

PRELUDE IV

A MOVEMENT in which the figures of the first bar are built up into a broadly melodic form, the important cadence in the dominant at bars 14-15 being distinctly reproduced in the tonic at bar 34. Bar 5 introduces other figures which are developed in the middle of the movement. Climaxes may be externally recognised by the presence of leger-lines below the bass stave, such notes being best dealt with on the clavichord as the result of a *crescendo*. But on the pianoforte it is hardly less dangerous to force the tone in Bach's pathetic melodies than on the clavichord.

The ornaments given in bold-type brackets [] were added to one of the autographs at an early date. However opinions may differ as to their authenticity, they are of special importance as showing, at the very least, how Bach allowed his best pupils to play his slow movements. Bischoff remarks truly that, though individually correct in style, they are never found in such profusion in a Bach autograph that has not been tampered with, nor are they to be found in another autograph of this particular prelude. All this, however, shows only (what we might have guessed) that Bach does not trouble to indicate ornaments which every "tasteful" player was supposed to include in his art of interpretation. What we have here is an unusually perfect record of the best ornaments for every point where ornament is admissible. The player must not be deprived of the power to make his own selection. Nor must the ornaments be so written out in ordinary notes as to obscure the main melody which they are to adorn. The player should first thoroughly learn the music without the ornaments, and then add them by degrees as the need becomes felt and the capacity develops for playing them naturally and lightly. The notation here adopted writes out all the ornaments as grace-notes (except the well-known ω and ψ); and appoggiaturas are to be taken at their own value as full-sized notes on the beat—*i.e.*, a small-print quaver is a quaver, and a crotchet a crotchet. A quite short single grace-note (or *Nachschlag*, as in the exceptional case at the end of bar 15, which is to be played before the next bar) is here written thus:  Ornaments not in brackets may be regarded as absolutely necessary. No ornament delays any note of another part: *e.g.* the grace-notes in bar 13 will coincide with the G $\sharp$ and F $\times$ of the inner part. But a long ornament will delay and shorten the quaver after a dotted crotchet, as in bar 29; thus 

The ornaments all show that no pupil of Bach doubted that this was a slow movement. The rhythmic figure  determines, on the other hand, that it shall not be too slow—*i.e.*, the quaver after the dot must neither drag as melody nor harshly dwell on casual transitions in the harmony.

FUGUE IV

IN this five-part Fugue a short principal Subject is first developed at some length by itself, with no fixed counterpoints. The tenor of bars 7-10 reproduces the bass of bar 5, but nothing more is heard of this except a figure of descending crotchets (bars 7, 9, 10, etc.) which, developed by inversion in bars 17-18, fills up most of the texture until the close of this section in bar 35, after which it gives rise to the Second Subject. At bar 35 the First Subject is combined with this Second Subject, a theme consisting chiefly of a sequence of flowing quavers which can uncoil itself indefinitely, and so do duty for more than one entry. Note its treatment by inversion in bars 41-43, the only detached Episode in the whole Fugue, which is from now onwards entirely occupied by entries of its Subjects. A third subject is added in bar 49, a formula with an emphatic rhythm. The Triple Counterpoint thus formed is worked out in its various positions (six permutations are possible and four are used, or five if our conjecture in bar 86 be correct) until

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bar 94, which begins the final section of the Fugue—a huge Stretto on the combination of First and Third Subjects.

From bar 85 to bar 94 the three upper parts are extremely difficult to unravel; and in bar 96 all the autographs give the high soprano F# the value of a semibreve, which would mean that a sixth part is suddenly required to account for all the entries. The ear is not worried by that, but it does demand to know what becomes of the soprano; and, if the semibreve is to stand, the soprano can neither proceed nor rest. Bischoff has found the indisputable and necessary solution of this problem by reading a minim followed by a crossing of parts.

Another problem, which remains open, is: whether in bar 86 the third part (from the top) does not cross over the second. If it does, then these parts remain crossed for the rest of the Fugue—a consequence of no concern to the listener. Also the Third Subject will alter its last note, which it can easily afford to do here as it does much more prominently in bar 94 and four other places. Lastly, there will be an imperfect fifth followed by a perfect fifth between the two upper parts at the moment of crossing, a matter which Bach seldom takes seriously. Against all this there is the almost irresistible temptation to see, in bars 85-87, another entry (in the subdominant) of the First Subject. Such an entry is well-timed: Bach is descending from a great climax produced by the bold and characteristic device of three successive entries of his Subjects all in the tonic (bars 73-83; compare the later stages of the great G minor Organ Fugue); the subsequent tonic entry in bar 89 is in the same position as the second of the three, and, coming five bars after the end of the third, is too late to add to the cumulative effect, and too soon to avoid weakening it, unless attention is strongly directed to the subdominant in bars 85-88. An entry of the First Subject in these bars exactly completes the scheme. The crossing of parts would be almost impossible to express on two staves without an eccentric use of leger-lines above the bass; so nothing can be argued from the failure of the manuscripts to substantiate it. The notation here adopted suggests the possibility without closing the question. As a matter of fact, any perceptible emphasis on the F# E# in bars 85-86 will infallibly suggest the rest of the Subject when its remaining notes are actually present in the harmony, whichever part takes them over. Perhaps this is why Bach did not trouble to settle the point. Certainly, if he wished to avoid suggesting the First Subject here, he would have had some other counterpoint than that clear skip up to the F# on the fourth crotchet of bar 85. One early edition has a crotchet rest before the F# as if to mark the entry.

The *tempo* is a broad two in the bar (equal in pace, but not in accent, to a flowing four). The climaxes are best attained slowly from a very quiet opening (such writing as that of the first 35 bars soon puts the pianoforte into a miserable light if the tone is forced), and an almost equally quiet though decisive fresh start (perhaps after a slight pause) at bar 35. By bar 66 matters are ripe for considerable power at the bold and surprising entry in D# minor. Such low bass-notes as those of the great entry in bar 73 implied for Bach the full power of his instrument.

Other entries requiring notice are, (1) the soprano in bar 48, where the theorist's view that the initial semibreve of the First Subject is here represented by the last quaver, will induce an ugly detachment or emphasis of that note. A more adequate view (borne out by Bach's procedure in numberless cases) is that the figure of the whole bar becomes construed as an ornament around that semibreve; so that the Second Subject broadens out into the First with a *crescendo*. (2) In bars 54-57 the soprano may well be read as an answer in stretto at cross-rhythm.

We know from Czerny that Beethoven contrived to express the long sustained notes of the final four bars by a *diminuendo* to *pianissimo*. On the pianoforte some *diminuendo* is unquestionably necessary, but if bar 112 is still struck in full tone the suspensions and long notes can be kept alive by unobtrusive repetition, as on the clavichord, where the tiny tone could bear thus renewing without limit. On no account must the suspended G# in bar 112 fail to be heard.